DAN KACHULA

SENIOR PRODUCT DESIGNER · UX STRATEGY & DESIGN SYSTEMS · AI-ASSISTED DESIGN

Charlotte, NC | kachdan@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/kachdan | kachdan.com | Open to Hybrid & Remote

SUMMARY

Senior product designer with 15+ years across enterprise design systems and internal business tooling in financial services. Runs discovery research, defines success criteria before build, validates assumptions through prototypes and moderated testing, and tracks outcomes after launch. Partners closely with engineering so design intent survives to implementation, including contributing front-end changes directly in the codebase. Owned an enterprise design system through a company-wide rebrand and scaled it as the design organization grew from 4 to 26 designers. Proposed and co-built an approved AI-assisted UI editor on the Claude Agent SDK, running against a firewalled internal gateway. Uses AI as leverage rather than a shortcut, because execution getting cheap is exactly what makes judgment and craft worth more.

CORE COMPETENCIES

End-to-End Product Design · Discovery Research · Journey Mapping & Information Architecture · Interaction Design & Rapid Prototyping · Usability Testing & Research · Personas · Design Systems & Component Libraries · Design Tokens & Figma Variables · Accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA) · Facilitation & Design Critique · AI-Assisted Design Workflows (Claude, MCP) · Design-to-Code Collaboration · Enterprise & Regulated Environments · Art Direction & Visual Design

EXPERIENCE

Moody's · MIS Tech

PRODUCT DESIGNER → DESIGN SYSTEM LEAD & ART DIRECTOR

JUN 2020 – JUN 2026 · CHARLOTTE, NC · HYBRID

> *Grew from product designer into design system lead and art director across six years, owning end-to-end product design for internal analyst platforms while building and scaling the technology organization's design system.*

END-TO-END PRODUCT DESIGN

- Sole designer on an internal business tooling platform consolidating credit review, deal intake, and rating-committee workflows for analysts, owning the work end to end from discovery through launch and post-launch iteration.
- Ran multi-week discovery research with analysts and product owners, mapping the process people actually followed across documents, spreadsheets, and email rather than the one that was documented, and defining both linear and non-linear task flows.
- Built journey maps quantifying time spent on correspondence, form completion, data logging, and analysis, then used them to define success criteria and set MVP scope before build began.
- Validated assumptions through prototypes and moderated usability sessions at MVP and at intervals after launch, correcting course while changes were still cheap.
- Embedded with engineering from sprint one, delivering MVP screens in parallel with backend development so design intent carried through to implementation.
- Cut daily task time from 30–60 minutes of manual work to under 10 minutes in the delivered application, tracked adoption after launch, and reached full analyst adoption supported by onboarding documentation I wrote.

AI-ASSISTED UI EDITOR (INTERNAL TOOL)

- Proposed and co-created an approved, AI-assisted UI editor that lets designers, product owners, and developers edit live Angular applications through natural language, with changes written to real project files and rendered instantly in an embedded preview.
- Brought the initial concept forward after legal and compliance restricted external generative design tools, then partnered daily with the lead engineer over two months to define and build the alternative.
- Conceived the element-picker interaction, letting users select a component in the live preview to capture its context for the AI, addressing the core challenge of communicating intent when prompting UI changes.
- Partnered on the design-system integration so generated output used Moody's custom Angular design system, built in-house on Tailwind, rather than generic markup.
- Contributed front-end changes directly in the codebase using VS Code and GitHub pull requests, covering layout, interaction, copy, and information architecture.
- Built on Electron, Angular, and the Claude Agent SDK, running against an internal firewalled LLM gateway rather than any external AI service, and approved for production rollout to roughly 50 developers along with designers and product owners across the internal tower.

DESIGN SYSTEM & DESIGN OPS

- Ran the design system as a product with three audiences: designers, developers, and product owners. Drove toward a single destination where a designer could read usage guidance, a developer could pull source, and a product owner could see a pattern running live, so a new application started from a working shell rather than a blank file.
- Took ownership of a nascent internal design system shortly after joining as a product designer, growing it from roughly 15 early components into a mature, versioned library (3.0.1) of 57 components as the design team scaled from 4 to 26 designers.
- Architected a three-tier design-token system of 400+ published variables spanning primitive, semantic, and typography collections, so a brand or theming change happened once at the primitive layer and traveled everywhere instead of becoming a hunt through hard-coded styles.
- Partnered with the lead design system engineer to keep the Figma component library and the coded Angular and Tailwind implementation in lockstep, so designers and developers drew from a single shared source.
- Co-led the team's 2024 migration from Axure to Figma with a design partner: evaluated and selected the platform, rebuilt the full component library with a deliberate, scalable architecture, and ran a three-month onboarding program of weekly workshops and one-on-one coaching. Served as one of three Figma administrators, owning license and access management.
- Authored component usage guidelines defining placement, behavior, tone, and variation, so designers and developers could apply the system correctly from a single destination.
- Drove a custom, dependency-free documentation site that surfaced live components, variations, and usage guidance in one place for designers and developers, a deliberate choice over Storybook given a dedicated engineering team and mature in-house system; more recently evaluated and worked in Storybook while integrating it with the internal builder.
- Oversaw design and design system use on the team's KPI dashboard project, reviewing screen layouts, chart usage, and component consistency for data visualizations built with Google Charts and later Chart.js.

ACCESSIBILITY

- Helped establish WCAG 2.1 AA as the accessibility target for the internal design system, and built compliance into components by default so color contrast, focus states, ARIA labeling, and field validations shipped accessible out of the box for every team that used them.
- Established a multi-signal error-handling pattern used across applications: field-level messaging pairing color with an icon rather than color alone, reinforced by page-level alerts so users are notified regardless of scroll position, plus error-prevention patterns like progressive disclosure and disabled-until-complete controls.

FACILITATION & DESIGN LEADERSHIP

- Facilitated twice-weekly design critique for a design organization that grew to 26 designers across Charlotte and New York, acting as a facilitator rather than a decision-maker, drawing out quieter and remote participants, and following up individually when a session ran short on time.
- Calibrated critique to each project's stage and coached designers on component selection and usage, using concrete decisions like radio buttons versus checkboxes to reinforce the reasoning behind design-system standards.
- Periodically brought senior leadership, including SVPs and Managing Directors, into critique sessions to show the rigor behind design decisions and build organizational understanding of design as human-centered problem-solving.

ENTERPRISE REBRAND & INTEGRATION

- Represented the technology organization's design team in Moody's company-wide rebrand (2023–2024), a multi-month initiative spanning logo, typography, color, and voice across an organization of approximately 15,000 people and several design teams.
- Translated finalized brand guidance into the design system so product designers stayed focused on delivery, working within constraints set at the enterprise level without breaking the teams downstream.
- Contributed the team's functional icon library to the enterprise effort, where it was adopted as one of three official iconography categories distributed company-wide.
- Defined the design requirements for embedding a separate document-extraction product within the analyst platform and guided engineering on implementation, so analysts could review source PDFs in-context through a seamless, SSO-authenticated experience.
- Maintained an external open-source icon library through an internal fork under version control, keeping the Figma icon set in sync with the engineering implementation as a single source of truth.

AI-DRIVEN EFFICIENCY

- Used AI-assisted workflows to rename and standardize a 1,500-icon library to a strict naming convention in a single afternoon, work equivalent to roughly a full week of manual effort, eliminating naming collisions across the system.
- Generated semantic descriptions for each icon so AI tools could select the right icon by meaning rather than filename, making the library machine-readable and future-ready for AI-assisted design workflows.

Wells Fargo · Digital Experience Design (DXD / XD) · Contract via ettain group

SENIOR VISUAL / EXPERIENCE DESIGNER

APR 2016 – OCT 2017, APR 2018 – JUN 2020 · CHARLOTTE, NC

- Designed authenticated online banking experiences on Digital Product Pages, the account and transaction views customers reach after signing in, which accounted for the bulk of four years of work, alongside projects on public wellsfargo.com.
- Carried three to four concurrent projects at a time inside a design triad of visual, interaction, and content strategy that handed off jointly to engineering on fixed sprint deadlines, through the organization's transition from waterfall to Agile.

- Designed the results experience for the public Debt-to-Income Ratio Calculator, a six-month build that translates a borrowing-health number into a color-graded scale readable at a glance, validated in moderated lab sessions and still live on wellsfargo.com today.
- Introduced clickable InVision prototypes to that effort, self-teaching the tool so research participants could exercise the calculator's real logic in testing instead of reacting to static comps.
- Ran the end-to-end design of a custom product icon for Charitable Giving in the Payments pod, iterating with product owners, the art director, and the enterprise brand team until it was accepted into Wells Fargo's official iconography library.
- Partnered on the organization's migration from Photoshop to Sketch, rebuilding page and component work into shared Sketch libraries as the firm stood up its first distributed design system for designers and engineers.
- Became the team's go-to for design UAT, inspecting built pages against spec in browser dev tools and coaching other designers to do the same, catching spacing, type, and component defects before release.
- Applied user-centered design methods across a broad customer demographic, including personas, usability testing, and design artifacts that improved consistency and stakeholder confidence across product teams.

KachDan Consulting · Independent UX / Product Design · Self-employed

SR. UX / INTERACTION / IA DESIGNER

MAY 2015 – MAR 2016, NOV 2017 – MAR 2018 · CHARLOTTE METRO

- Delivered full UX and visual design engagements for multiple clients simultaneously, spanning research, information architecture, responsive redesign, and front-end implementation.
- Redesigned enterprise and small-business web applications from legacy interfaces to modern, conversion-focused experiences grounded in user-centered design.

Mergent, Inc. · Financial Data & Business Intelligence

UX / INTERACTION / IA CONSULTANT

OCT 2014 – MAR 2015 · FORT MILL, SC

- Redesigned the legacy Mergent Intellect web application to a modern, semi-flat interface, partnering with the VP of Product Management to define the UX and product design strategy.
- Refined the information architecture and reorganized content areas, then established user-experience methodologies and industry best practices for the team.
- Developed user stories and high-fidelity wireframes and mockups, and built efficient, reusable design components.

Earlier Experience

SENIOR UX DESIGNER & PRODUCT MANAGER · INTERACTION DESIGNER · MOTION & VISUAL DESIGN

2006 – 2014

- Owned the UX process end to end across product and consulting roles: research, wireframing, prototyping, specifications, and finished UI, plus early-career motion graphics and visual design.

TOOLS & TECHNOLOGY

DESIGN & PROTOTYPING: Figma (primary), FigJam, Adobe Creative Suite, ProtoPie, Miro, Axure

DESIGN SYSTEMS: Design tokens, Figma variables, component-library governance, usage documentation, Storybook (familiar)

AI & DEVELOPER TOOLS: Claude, Claude Code, Claude Agent SDK, MCP, VS Code, GitHub, AI-assisted design workflows

FRONT-END FAMILIARITY: TypeScript, JavaScript (ES6+), HTML5, CSS3 / SASS, Tailwind, Angular components, Chart.js, design-to-dev handoff, responsive design

RESEARCH & COLLABORATION: Usability testing, user interviews, task analysis, Jira, Confluence, Agile / Scrum

EDUCATION

HUMAN FACTORS INTERNATIONAL (HFI) · CUA program coursework (2015), covering user-centered analysis, usability testing, and Voice User Interface (VUI) design.

HUMAN FACTORS INTERNATIONAL · Human-Computer Interaction coursework (2012–2013).

HENNEPIN TECHNICAL COLLEGE · Web & Graphic Design / Media Communication (2003–2005).